



2025 FORUM

Anderson Clarke Center • Rice University • Houston, TX

A dynamic forum advancing the lives of the neurodivergent community through
Data-Driven Insights • Employment • Entrepreneurship • Inclusion Through Sports

JOIN THE GENERATION OF INCLUSION AND CHANGE

01 — ABOUT GENUINE CONNECT

DO SOMETHING **GENUINE.**

Get ready to be inspired, empowered, and connected. You are invited to a dynamic and impactful event dedicated to advancing the lives of the neurodivergent community through focused discussions on Data-Driven Insights, Employment, Entrepreneurship, and the Power of Inclusion Through Sports.

Genuine Connect is a seminar and forum focused on employment and inclusion for people with intellectual disabilities. It engages legislators, policymakers, corporate leaders, and advocacy groups in institutional dialogue that drives real change.

1,000+

ATHLETES EMPOWERED

4

EXPERT PANELS

02 — LEADERSHIP TEAM

MEET OUR **LEADERS**



IGNACIO TORRAS

CEO, Tricon Energy
Founder & Executive Director, Genuine World
Cup



DR. LORNA ORTIZ

CCO, GeoKiln Energy
Founder & President, The Genuine
Foundation

03 — SPECIAL REMARKS

DAVID BALDWIN

SPECIAL REMARKS

David Baldwin joined SCF Partners in 1991 and currently is responsible for the firm's energy transition initiatives. In this role, he is responsible for SCF's energy transition strategy, including identifying new platform investments, and helping SCF's existing companies develop exposure to new energy growth markets.

David's civic activities include Greentown Labs, Pursuit Center, and Baylor College of Medicine, including serving as the Chairman of their Board of Trustees. In 2016, he and his wife Maire created "Pursuit for Those with Disabilities," where they led 300 volunteers in a cross-country bicycle ride that raised \$13 million to help build a new state-of-the-art campus for Pursuit Center.

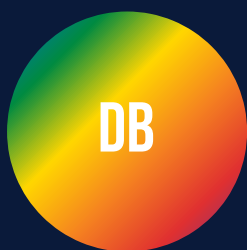
In 2018, he was awarded the Hoover Medal of Honor for his 30+ years of work supporting persons with disabilities.



Partner, SCF Partners

04 — FEATURED KEYNOTE

DANI BOWMAN



CEO, DaniMation
Entertainment

FEATURED KEYNOTE

Dani Bowman is a young and talented animator, artist, and entrepreneur on the Autism Spectrum who is passionate about using her skills to help others and her dedication to inclusion and diversity.

Despite being diagnosed with autism at age 3 and nonverbal until 6, Dani has overcome these challenges to become an accomplished artist, animator, and inspiring speaker. She founded her own company, DaniMation, when she was just 14 years old, and DaniMation UK in 2019.

Dani has taught animation to over 3,000 students with autism and premiered 14 short films at San Diego Comic-Con. As a national speaker and cast member of Love on the Spectrum, Dani uses her platform to inspire and mentor others.

2025 FORUM PANELS

Four expert panels bring together leaders from data science, employment, entrepreneurship, and sports to chart new paths for neurodivergent inclusion.

PANEL 1

DATA & INSIGHTS — SHAPING SOLUTIONS

Moderated by Michael A. Giongo

PANEL 2

EMPLOYMENT — ENTERPRISE & GOVERNMENT

Moderated by Jose Velasco

PANEL 3

ENTREPRENEURS IN THE ECOSYSTEM

Moderated by Dr. Lorna Ortiz

PANEL 4

SPORTS AS A VENUE FOR INCLUSION

Moderated by Dr. Lorna Ortiz

PANEL 1

DATA & INSIGHTS — SHAPING SOLUTIONS



MODERATOR

MICHAEL A. GIONGO

Sports Data Analyst & Strategist



DR. LUZ MARIA GARCINI

Director of Community and Public Health, Kinder Institute, Rice University



JUDGE LINA HIDALGO

Harris County Judge



CHARLES NJUGUNA

President & CEO, Pursuit Center



DR. RUTH N. LÓPEZ TURLEY

Director, Kinder Institute for Urban Research, Rice University



JOSE VELASCO

SVP, Strategic Operations, Autism Society of America

PANEL 2

EMPLOYMENT — ENTERPRISE & GOVERNMENT



MODERATOR

JOSE VELASCO

SVP, Autism Society of America



TOM D'ERI

Co-Founder, Rising Tide Car Wash • Forbes 30 Under 30



RISSA MCGURN

Senior Advisor, Diversity Talent Management, Chevron



MELINDA PANINSKI

Communications & Partnerships Manager, Texas Workforce Commission

PANEL 3

ENTREPRENEURS IN THE ECOSYSTEM



MODERATOR

DR. LORNA ORTIZ

CCO, GeoKiln Energy; President, Genuine Foundation



ROD BATSON

CEO, Howdy Homemade Ice Cream



GUY BENHAM

Owner & CEO, Jessie's Bites



DANI BOWMAN

CEO & Founder, DaniMation Entertainment



MIKE GIONGO

Sports Data Analyst & Strategist

PANEL 4

SPORTS AS A VENUE FOR INCLUSION



MODERATOR

DR. LORNA ORTIZ

President, The Genuine Foundation



JOAO GOMIERO

Co-Founder Project Inspire · Professional Athlete, Richmond Kickers



LINDA MASTRANDREA

Manager of Accessibility, FIFA World Cup 2026



MAJD STEITIEH

Director, Soccer Growth, U.S. Soccer



IGNACIO TORRAS

CEO Tricon Energy; Exec. Director, Genuine World Cup

UPCOMING 2026 FORUM THEMES

Three pillars of focus will define the upcoming 2026 forum — each driving toward measurable progress for the neurodivergent community.



GENUINE IN FOCUS: DATA AND INSIGHTS

Experts from diverse fields will share insights on how we can help shape solutions to improve the lives of the Genuine community. Data-driven approaches to policy, education, and employment outcomes.



EMPLOYMENT AS A DIFFERENTIATOR

Real-world examples and expertise on how Genuine inclusion fosters organizational capabilities and opportunity. From Fortune 500 companies to innovative startups.



DRIVING INCLUSION THROUGH SPORTS

Driving inclusion through sports and building on the La Liga Genuine Methodology around the world. Sport as a universal language for belonging and empowerment.

07 — ACCESSIBILITY

A GREAT EXPERIENCE **FOR EVERYONE**

SENSORY BREAK ROOM

Guests who need a quiet space to take a break are welcome to visit our sensory break room located near the auditorium. Our friendly staff is here to help with any of your needs.

COMMUNICATION PREFERENCES

Color Communication Stickers at the Forum are a system first developed in Autistic spaces. They help people tell others about their communication preferences.



Green = Open to talk · Yellow = Familiar faces only · Red = Prefer solitude

08 — VENUE & LOGISTICS

GETTING **THERE**

ANDERSON CLARKE CENTER

Susanne M. Glasscock School of Continuing Studies, Rice University, Houston, TX

Spend two days with us at Rice University! Our agenda is packed with amazing speakers and experts from across the US. Whether you are local to Houston, or coming from out of town, we are here to answer your questions on Genuine Connect logistics.

Visit genuinefoundation.org/genuine-connect for full agenda and travel details.

JOIN THE GENERATION OF **INCLUSION AND CHANGE**

Register now for Genuine Connect 2025 and be part of the movement transforming how the world sees, values, and includes neurodiverse talent.

REGISTER NOW